

I = interviewer
P = participant

I: Alright. So, to start, how would you like us to refer to your partner?

P: You don't prefer his first name, so I don't know.

I: However you want. It can be his first name.

P: It can be his first name, but it's just that... I don't know if you're also going to do... I mean, you're doing all the interviews and maybe you want to avoid understanding who is who, right? I mean, I don't know.

I: No worries, no.

P: No, you don't care. Yeah, in that case, it can be his first name then. His name is (partner).

I: Ok, (partner). And how long have you been with (partner)?

P: Well, since [Date], so it's been about [1-5] and a half years.

I: Ok, very good. I'd like you to tell me about your love story, the relationship you currently have with him.

P: So, in a very general way, you're not necessarily talking about our meeting, so...

I: Yes, yes, yes.

P: Yes? Ok. Well, we met somewhat by chance in the sense that I went because he lives in [Country], I live in [Country]. So, initially, we're not in the same country. But I had the opportunity to go work in [Country] for [1-5] months initially. And then, we met more or less through friends. That is to say, I had an acquaintance there who allowed me to meet people at the university where he worked. We're in a field not quite similar in terms of work, but actually not that far apart either. And we quickly realized that we had a lot in common actually. Whether it was in our professional interests, what we like to do on the side, sports, activities in general. And I think what made our meeting really quite simple was that there was something very natural when we talked together because we were able to... I don't know how to say, but to share a lot of things while knowing that we were both interested, both curious, both... So, we had this ease of talking to each other. That still remains today actually. It's really something for me at least that was quite new to be able to meet someone who made me feel like myself directly. It's like I could be myself, and even more myself when he was around. So, that's kind of how we met. So, in the end, through these groups of friends, we very quickly wanted to share moments together with the things we liked to do. Whether it was sports or other things. And that's how the relationship developed gradually.

I: So how did it develop thanks to your common interests?

P: Yes, thanks to our common interests, thanks to, I think, the closeness we managed to achieve, the intimacy we were able to quickly have in what we shared as well. That is to say, we very quickly shared very personal things. We... At least, I think we also easily opened up to each other about how we felt, etc. I think one of the great things I have is that (partner) seems to me to be someone extremely emotionally mature. And that really helped the process gradually because I was coming out of a relationship that was very, very complicated, which was extremely toxic for me and made me extremely unhappy. And a lot on the... How do you say... I was very defensive, I was extremely attentive to everything. And with (partner), it was just extremely simple. He gave me confidence, in myself, in him, and in the relationship actually. Where before, I had a tendency to overthink, make assumptions, ask why this, why that? With

him, never. I never had that feeling of making up stories in my head. Everything was very reassuring actually. And I think that helped a lot for me in transitioning from a very toxic relationship to this relationship which is really healthy in itself in the bonds we have with each other.

I: Ok. And after that, how did it go when you got together?

P: Well, where it might have been somewhat unnatural is that I continued to live in [City A] and he in [Country]. Even though I worked between [City A] and [Country], which is still the case today, by the way. So, we had and still have times when we are separated, meaning we are apart for [1-5] weeks, a month without seeing each other, and times when we live together because I go to his place. Naturally, firstly because we don't want to spend money and secondly because we want to be together when I am there. So, we are in a dynamic that is a bit complicated because we are either together all the time or not at all. Where I think for me, it would have probably been easier to have a relationship where we can see each other regularly but maybe not all the time at first because we are getting to know each other as well. So, there are things that can be... At first, we want to maintain this intimacy. So, for me, it was the first time I had a long relationship where I found myself in this situation where I live with him even though it happened very quickly that we had to share the space since, yes, from the first times we were together, even after [1-5] month, when I went to see him, I stayed at his place. So, we still have this dynamic today. So, it's been [1-5] and a half years that we have lived like this where I am... It's mainly me who travels back and forth since I work in both places, so it's kind of logical. So, for him, it's more... Sometimes he's alone at home, sometimes I'm there actually. And the relationship just developed like that. When I left [Country] initially, he just said to me, "Well, we try actually, we see if we can manage to have this mid-distance, mid-you're-here relationship." And it went well. Every time I went there, it was just very simple, very natural. We shared moments together, and gradually, we got used to it. And here we are, [1-5] and a half years later, without even realizing it.

I: So, in the end, yes, you still manage to make the distance work.

P: Yes, completely. Plus, now he has gone even further away for some time, so yes, we are used to it.

I: Very good. Now, if you had to compare the quality of your current couple relationship with the quality of your friends' relationships, what would you say?

P: Compared to my friends, it's not easy. I would have had more ease comparing it with my other relationships, I think. Regarding my friends... Well, I think we are all different. Everyone has a different dynamic and everyone needs a different dynamic. I have friends who need to be very close in their relationship and therefore spend much more time together than I do with (partner) because... Due to the distance but also because I think, naturally, I also need time alone. So, for that, I think it can... Well, from the outside, some might say they are not close so do they really have a relationship made of love, etc. But for me, yes. Ah yeah, it's difficult to compare to other couples, actually. Well, if I compare it quite categorically, we rarely argue. We really have very, very few disagreements. It's not because we avoid disagreements or because we say yes to everything the other does. It's just that once again, (partner) is someone very calm and with great understanding, with very high emotional intelligence, so it makes things very easy. Whereas I think I'm not that easy, actually. I think it's really him and his calmness and his extremely mature way that helped the relationship to take the shape it has today. So,

yes, I think I owe him a lot for how our relationship has developed gradually. So, we have very few moments of disagreement, let's say. What else is there to compare, actually? I'm realizing. I think once again, we share the same passions and so, we have many goals and we anticipate and want to share many things in the future. So, we don't have projects... we don't have a child project, we don't have a buying project, things that usually unite couples, that's not our case. But we have many projects, things we want to do, experiences we want to have, not necessarily professional ones because we don't have quite the same job, but at least, on a personal level, we want to do things together. And I think that is very, very empowering too because it allows us to dream together and all that. Then, I think another determinant generally of couples is humor. So, I have very complicated humor, really, to make me laugh, you really have to search a lot to find my type of humor, etc. And I have very, I think, complex humor, really not immediate anyway. And he manages to make me laugh. So, for me, it's incredible. Plus, it wasn't even a criterion for me initially, but here, in any case, it works very, very well. We get along well on humor, on having a good time, sharing things that make us happy, etc. What else? I think we are also accomplices. There is great complicity in the way we... That is to say, when we are together, we have a way of being that is really just between us. I think it's the case for many couples, but... or even all couples. But it's true that I feel this complicity too, where I didn't necessarily feel it in other relationships. I think my friends have that too. They are accomplices with their partners, but I can see that I couldn't be an accomplice. If we had to switch, there would be no complicity. That's it. I don't know if... tell me if there are things that come to mind... I: I'm here to gather what you tell me, so no worries. But then, complicity, for example, is important.

P: Yes, yes, yes. I really think complicity is very important. Before, I don't know if I would have told you that because I hadn't felt it. So, I said to myself, well, it wasn't that important. But once you know it and experience it, you say, yes, in fact, it's so much easier to be with someone who understands what will make me laugh, who understands what I will like, who will join in the same fun or in the same things, in the same cute stuff, so to speak. Well, we don't seem silly at all. We just seem like two people having fun. I use particular expressions.

I: No worries, really. As I said, there are no right or wrong answers. And precisely, you tell me it would be easier for you to compare with your previous relationships. I'd like you to tell me a little about that, if you had to compare with your previous relationships, what would you say?

P: Well, as I said just before, I had a very toxic relationship for me. And I had very few relationships, actually. That is to say, despite my age today, I only had [1-5] long relationships before... well, long, I put long in quotes. I had a [1-5] -year relationship and a [1-5] -year relationship, actually. And both relationships were quite disastrous. My very first one, I was quite young, so it's quite normal, I think, to search, to discover oneself, etc. But I was with someone with whom I also shared the same interests for many things. At least for sports. A little less on the intellectual side, we had fewer things in common, I'd say. But it doesn't change that he was a very curious person and I think that's something important to me. So... But my first relationship was very, very complicated for many reasons, but because we were both very young and I needed a lot of reassurance. I was with someone who didn't reassure at all. And it was someone who hadn't decided to settle down yet and he just needed to have his experiences. So, I was more of an obstacle to the experiences he could live in his life than wanting to live them with me, actually, I think, on many levels. So, it was a very complicated

relationship, very conflictual because we both had quite strong characters, I think. My other relationship, when I say it was toxic, it's not an exaggeration because it was a time when I think I was very fragile from the start, but this relationship clearly led me towards depression because I don't know if... Clearly, in any case, he and I, it didn't work because we were completely different. We had different desires, we had a very different age, that is to say, he was [6-10] years younger than me and I realized it wasn't the best... Well, it was very difficult for me, at least, to handle this age difference. Maybe less for him, but at least for me, it was complicated. And we were so different that it was extremely difficult for me to be who I am without feeling judged, without feeling that I was, in quotes, off base or without feeling that it was strange to be like that. I always had the impression I had to adapt to a way of being. And I think... I don't know what your field of research is, by the way, but I studied [program], I did therapy for [1-5] years, so I have a lot of psychological and psychoanalytical understandings of why I sought this relationship. But maybe we should avoid going into that field because it's very specific, but somewhere, I was looking to find a complementarity, that is to say something different from me and so why am I different? Understand a bit what I'm missing, in quotes, and then confront the other who is complementary. But actually, I realized it wasn't complementary, it was just opposite. Where we can be with someone who is complementary and with whom it's simple and we are in agreement, etc. And I think at that time, I understood this difference. Being with someone opposite to me was just very, very difficult. Don't hesitate to ask me more specific questions because it can help me sometimes. Because otherwise, I struggle a bit to synthesize things for you.

I: No worries, really. I'm just gathering what you're telling me. But precisely, one of the differences that stands out is the fact that you were opposite. And so, it's different from your current relationship where you are much more similar. And so, that's something important to you.

P: So, yes, that's the first thing that comes to mind. But I think if we go really deeper, no, there are many other things that are still different. Once again, I think the fact that (partner) is extremely emotionally mature... Did I lose you?

I: No, it's good.

P: So yes, I was saying that the fact that (partner) is very emotionally mature, that he is extremely empathetic, that he has a really... It was quite surprising to me by the way that he had this ease to understand me and empathize and have a benevolent position towards me. Where my previous relationships, let's say the first one, it was just someone who wasn't necessarily mean, but who was very self-centered. At least, who was very self-absorbed. And then well, there you go. And the second person was clearly very, very unhappy, I think. And he sought rather to crush the other as much as possible. I think the age difference, the fact that I was older, etc. must have emphasized that too. But there was really this need to constantly crush me which literally destroyed me actually. I felt drained of my energy when I was with him, whereas a relationship should be the opposite, I think. And so, the real difference with (partner) is that he makes me feel better. He is always there for me. He is benevolent. He helps me. He is extremely attentive too. That's very, very rare, I find. At least in the circle I grew up in, it's true that men are not the most attentive people. He is. So, there you go. Those are the real big differences, actually. I think I could be with someone with whom I share the same interests, but who would not be at all as benevolent. And so, it would not be the same thing at all. I think

(partner) is also someone who understood my sensitivity and who is careful and very attentive, actually, to how he says things, why he will say them, etc. Whereas in my other relationships, they could use my sensitivity rather to manipulate. Because it's simple to manipulate someone when you see their weaknesses, when you see their vulnerabilities, etc. And before, I had the impression that they would touch right where it hurts to trigger an emotion, trigger a behavior, etc. Whereas now, it's the opposite. I am fully supported for these sensitivities.

I: Yes, so one of the differences is that he is more attentive to you, you feel heard.

P: Yes, exactly. Understood as well, actually.

I: So precisely, I'd like you to tell me what you think a high-quality relationship is.

P: A relationship with respect, with love and consideration for the other, care too, benevolence, support, that is to say, uplifting the other, generosity. I think it's very important to be generous towards the other. Generous with everything, by the way. Time, resources, presence too. I think that's also a good relationship. It's a relationship of presence. And when we are with the other, we are there. And I think that's important. So, sharing and complicity, as we said earlier. And then a common vision, still. Sharing what we want to do, what we want to live. And I think very, very importantly... Oh, and I could go back to one of the questions you asked at first. But sharing fundamental values. And I say this because you asked me the question about my friends. You know that I didn't immediately think of a couple of friends who are actually quite easy for me to compare. It's that my friend, she has been with her boyfriend for six years. They know each other very well. They live together. But now, she is facing a very, very difficult moment in her relationship because they don't share the same fundamental values in life. And so, now they are facing important questions, whether buying a house, having children, what they want to do with their lives and what their professional desires are. And they constantly disagree. And that creates a lot of disputes, even though they are two people who don't argue. That is to say, they are two people who are calm, who are extremely attentive, etc. Everything I told you before, I think they both have. But now, they are facing a moment in their lives where they don't share the same values and the same desires for the future. And that's ruining everything, literally. And I see it because I've known my friend for a long time. So, I know her well. I know how she is. I share the values she shares. Well, we share more or less the same values, I think. And so, it's more her boyfriend who, for me, has values more different from mine. I think he has many friends who agree with him. But I realize I couldn't be with someone who has values so opposed to mine, even though he could have all the other qualities. It's too, too complicated to live with someone who doesn't share the same values. So yes, I think that's very important too. I have a lot of trouble using the word love or loving or other. It's not something that comes naturally to me. Probably because I think I grew up in an environment where it wasn't said. However, I think that love, the way I define it, is more through actions. That is to say, I don't have... Well, saying that I don't need to be told "I love you" isn't necessarily true, but it doesn't change that I think I see through actions and the presence of the other, etc., if there is love or not. So, it's true that I haven't used the word love much here, but I think it's because it goes through many other things, as I said before, with respect, benevolence, generosity, etc.

I: And precisely, you said a high-quality relationship is a respectful relationship. How can we know we are in a respectful relationship?

P: I think, once again, it's about listening, but also about deep listening to what the other person wants, when they want it, how we can do things, not imposing a point of view, not imposing

desires, not imposing anything, actually. Being in communication, I think that's fundamental to a relationship, communication. And I think it's very important to respect who the other person is, even if it happens in all relationships that we have moments when we are different, where we have different opinions. And I think we shouldn't impose our own vision on the other, we should try to listen and hear them. For me, it can be a bit difficult because sometimes I have very strong opinions. And I know it's not that easy, maybe for (partner), but he is so attentive, so calm and composed about these things that I find it also calms me down and allows me to be more respectful towards him, how he thinks about things. Because he remains calm. And respect is also, I think, seeing the other person in a positive light. It's somewhat, not necessarily having admiration, because I think admiration can turn very bad when we have too much of it. But at least, having this positive opinion of the person and saying, yes, they are a good person, and that's it.

I: Yes, I see. You also talked to me about benevolence, and so the same question, how can you know you are in a benevolent relationship?

P: I think there are several ways to know it. The first is, clearly, I have an intuition, that is to say there are things we feel very well, and I think we can very, very quickly feel that something is off. Sometimes, we just feel that the person in front of us doesn't exactly want your well-being or your happiness. They are looking for something more for themselves. We feel there is this one-sided aspect, actually, yes, it's more to make themselves feel good, etc. I think there are really these people where we know they are not in the right place with themselves at that moment, and they just come to seek something in the other. So yes, I think there is something very intuitive. We feel it when someone is benevolent with us, there is something that, as I said at the very beginning, with (partner), it was directly reassuring for me. I wasn't afraid that when I was here in Paris, something else would happen there. I wasn't afraid that eventually, he would change his mind and I wouldn't hear from him anymore. I knew he would be respectful and benevolent towards who he is and that he would take his responsibilities, and whatever happens, he would say it actually. He would say, well listen, we are not on the same page, or this or that. I knew there was something about thinking about how the other would receive things. So, I think after that, it's also the behavior the other has towards us, of course. So, if they are benevolent, they will take the time to listen, they will take the time to be present, they will take the time to understand, they will be there for the difficult moments, even if those moments are long sometimes, it can be months when we are not well, but they are still there. I think it's all that makes benevolence. It's looking out for the other, actually, when we think about it, it's someone who looks out for us, and who is there to make us feel better, and who supports us no matter what. And who will also allow us to look out for ourselves better than we can sometimes, reminding us to be kind to ourselves, have compassion, etc. Someone who will always be kind too, who won't have that hurtful word, that thing that comes and stings right where it hurts.

I: So it's someone who pays attention to us and helps us also to pay attention to ourselves.

P: Yes, exactly.

I: And when could you say your relationship has been benevolent? Do you have an example of a situation?

P: Yes, there are many, but let me think. Well, almost at the beginning of our relationship, about [6-10] months in, my parents got divorced and he was in [Country], I was in [City A], and he immediately took a train to come and help me. And that was really, for me, an extremely

benevolent gesture because he understood, even though I wasn't asking at all, that I wasn't asking him to be present, he understood that by doing it, by being there and being present, and at that moment, really listening to me, understanding my reactions, understanding my behaviors, understanding why it could be difficult for me, that was a quite significant act of benevolence, I think. And beyond that, I think he also very well understood, or at least, he took the time to understand that what I was going through was modifying our relationship, actually. And he didn't take things personally, I think that's also one of his great strengths, that he doesn't take things personally and understood that it was the situation I was living with my family that was very complicated and impacted our relationship necessarily. But he never reproached me or had hurtful words to make me feel guilty or anything.

I: So he paid attention to your feelings?

P: Yes, and to my situation too. And I think what was very benevolent too is that the times when I questioned myself, when I wondered why I felt that way, why I was so down, etc. Well, over time, I mean. And he was always there to remind me, well yes, but on the other hand, there is this situation with your family, there is this, it accumulates, it's normal that you feel that way. He allows me to take a step back from my own situation sometimes, where others might think, well yes, but now, get up, it's nice, but now you bore me every night talking about this for three hours, I don't have the right to spend a single evening. Really, there are many times when I found he had incredible patience with me, where I, myself, would have thought, well, now, it's enough. But no, he was extremely understanding and in the long term, that's what I want to say too, which surprised me because, actually, I think taking the train and coming, many would do that. Well, many, I don't know, but at least, it seems a bit like the romantic gesture we imagine in movies, etc. But in the long term, he was present and that's what seemed the most benevolent to me, actually.

I: Yes, I understand. And then, maybe, do you have an example where it was less benevolent?

P: Well... Actually, no. No. Honestly, no, not yet anyway. I think maybe he will go through difficult moments in his life and in that case, I expect it and I think it would be normal. But for now, I have to say that, really, no.

I: It's not mandatory if you don't have any. So, let's do the opposite. What would be, for you, a low-quality relationship?

P: Well, there is low quality and there is toxic relationship. So, if I talk just about low quality, I think it would be a relationship that is not fulfilling, actually. I think it's really easy to stay in a relationship with someone with whom it's okay, with whom we get by, with whom daily life is just fine, but who doesn't fulfill us, who doesn't make us grow, where we don't dream together, where we don't share anymore, actually. I think we don't communicate anymore, we have nothing more to say to each other. I see many families, well, many families and people, I think, rather from our parents' generation who can get to that point in their relationship. And I think it's something I would not like to experience. Even though I think it's part of time passing too, it's kind of logical, that we have less to say, etc. For sure. But for once, I have seen relationships not fade with time, actually. Really, just, they were still as vibrant with each other, [11-15] years, [11-15] years, [16-20] years later, actually. And that, I find quite impressive. So, it's not forgetting the other and continuing to give them an important place in your life, actually. So, yes, for me, a low-quality relationship would be that, being together, but ultimately not being present to each other and just being in a daily routine that makes us forget the other is there, actually.

That their presence is just a habit, almost. That it's taken for granted too, I think, this feeling of being taken for granted, it's what spoils some relationships, I think. That's it.

I: So it would be a bit like a relationship where we just settle and forget we are two in this relationship.

P: Yes, exactly. And maybe we individualize our way of thinking, we individualize the things we want to do. We think about ourselves first and then we are no longer in communication to do more or less what we want, actually.

I: And do you feel there was a moment when your relationship was like that?

P: No, because it's still... It's relatively not very long, at least for some people. For me, it's almost the longest I've had. But [1-5] and a half years, I don't think so. As I said, I think with my parents' divorce, there was a sort of break because I was at a point in my life where I found it harder to be present for the other person. I know how I felt, I don't know how he felt, but I felt a distance, actually, at some point that I needed to put between him and me, more to protect myself, I think, because I was dealing with my parents' divorce. So, suddenly, you think, well, should we rely on someone else to that extent? Not necessarily, because you realize it's never for the long term, actually. In any case, you always fear, what if we lose them? So, I had a bit of a tendency to tell myself, well, actually, I need to stay independent, rely on myself, etc. So, at that moment, I would say there was a period of distancing, at least, well, not a real distance, but something where I felt that something had changed at that moment. So, that's it, but otherwise, no, I don't think we've reached that stage yet in our relationship, but well, we haven't passed the [1-5]-year or [6-10]-year mark, so...

I: Yes, I see, yes. And finally, if perhaps there's an example of a moment when it happened like that, when perhaps you saw the relationship resurface? I don't know if...

P: You mean in the sense that at some point, it was the opposite, it was really...

I: You're talking a bit about forgetting the relationship, exactly, at the moment, yes.

P: So, maybe it wasn't quite forgetting, but more of a distance, but I think it's through the moments we shared that were strong that we also found each other again... I wouldn't say we forgot each other, that's really a strong term, because that's not the case, I felt there was a bit of a change, but I'm also extremely sensitive to change, I quickly say to myself, "oh, something's happening," when it's part of life too, and I think that's why he's much calmer. But yes, I think it's the moments we shared, like trips or things like that, that also make us rediscover each other's presence, and ultimately also the distance, that is, the times when we're separated again for almost a month, when we see each other again, it's true that I think it always creates a bit of highs and lows, I'm not saying in our relationship, but in the fact that there's a gap because we don't see each other, when we meet again, there's always that moment of "oh, we're seeing each other again and rediscovering each other," there's a bit of that special temporality. Every time we meet again, it's a bit like that.

I: Yes, so it's in the moments spent together, and a bit, it's the absence that also fuels it...

P: That's it, exactly, I think so, clearly. The times when we stay together for a long time, well, a long time in our case is a month, a month and a half let's say, all the time together, it's true that there are moments when we need to take back our space, to be with ourselves, etc. And I think that's something, if we are to live together all the time, that I'll need to manage well to ensure I have "me time," let's say, which will be very, very important for me to realign with myself, and then be present for the other. Because otherwise, I tend to need my bubble.

I: Yes, I see. So yes, it's also important to have personal time.

P: Completely, I think, and to have the things we love doing as well. As I told you, I'm not very fusionnal, I don't think I have a very fusionnal trait. So I need moments where, actually, it's my passion, it's me who, I like doing it alone. So there are quite a few things I like to keep in my sphere. So yes, a need for a bit of independence too, clearly, because that's how we're happy to find each other again.

I: Yes, I see. So, you talked to me about respect, benevolence, as important in a relationship. I'd like you to tell me about other things, if there are any, that could be important for you in a romantic relationship.

P: Hmm... Hmm...

I: If there are other things...

P: Yes, it's true, I'm thinking. I think communication is very important, as we said earlier too. It's very... being able to communicate, to be able to... well, intimacy too, in every respect, actually. That is, being able to reveal yourself to the other, to strip down, but not only through sexuality, but also through our feelings, our vulnerability. All that, I think it's very important to feel good and reassured with the other, to be able to be authentic to who we are, actually. I think it ties in a bit with respect, in a way, but it's still... Yes, it's the idea that maybe there's a symbiosis between the two people, harmony, let's say. Well, like complicity, in a way. I think there's also a somewhat, how do you say... probably somewhat chemical or physiological factor, that when we're together, there are pheromones, something happens, actually. There are butterflies in the stomach, there's desire, there's passion that's there. And I think that's also very, very important, even if it's probably harder to really explain, I think, probably because it's very personal to each person. But that, I think it's very important to note, anyway.

I: The feeling.

P: Yes, feeling that something is happening, that it's chemical between the two, actually. That there's this passion that's present, I think, in every way, actually. Because... Yes.

I: So passion is important too.

P: Yes, clearly, I think it's... As I told you, you can have people who are... You can have the most benevolent and respectful person in front of you. It won't necessarily create a couple, actually. It will just be a relationship of mutual respect, but it won't be a couple. I think to make a couple, there are still many ingredients to put in the potion, so to speak, magical. Because it's very complex. There has to be kindness and listening, etc. But also passion. I know many people talk about open relationships or the opportunity to have multiple partners. Precisely because of this difficulty, it's very hard to find everything in one partner. And I think it depends on personalities, but some need to be able to live different things. Because we're all different and we all need, I think, some complementarity with different people. So yes, it's very complicated to find it in one person, but I think it's really part of the important things. And another thing that comes to mind just now is trust. You really need to trust the other and yourself, to be able to live a relationship well.

I: Yeah, it's important.

P: Hmm. Hmm... That's it.

I: Yeah, yeah, that's important. I'd like you to tell me now, from your experiences and background, what love is for you. In general, it can be in a couple, in friendship.

P: Well, yes, and well, I've long... Since I've had very few romantic relationships, in quotes, well, in a couple, actually, I've also cultivated friendly love a lot. So, I think it's something that indeed doesn't just exist between two people in a couple. Hmm... As I told you before, I think in my family, we grew up with very little... How to say? Communication of love or how we... If we love the other, etc. Hmm... Which... So, for me, love is expressed a lot through gestures and actions in daily life. Hmm... And once again, I think love is being present for others at all moments of their life. In the sense... When they are down, when they are up, to share different things. And hmm... It's a complex question, I realize. Hmm... Hmm hmm hmm hmm... It's... Well, yes, I think it's sharing above all. It's feelings, obviously. It's attachment. Hmm... It's a certain vulnerability because you're okay with getting attached. Hmm... Hmm... I think love is also what gives beauty to things. Hmm... Hmm... I'm not a great poet, but...

I: No worries.

P: Yes. Hmm... Yeah, no, I find it hard to really define it.

I: No worries. That's fine with what you're saying. And precisely, we know there are different forms and ways to express love. I'd like you to tell me how you know your partner loves you?

P: Well, we say it to each other anyway. Hmm... We show it a lot in writing. Because we communicate a lot in writing too when we're not together, when we're apart at least. I think it also goes a lot through the complicity I mentioned. The fact that we share the same little quirks, the same little things we share. We have habits too that show, well, yes, there is love. Because, well, thinking of the other in the morning or evening, knowing they are always in a little corner of our mind or sending a little message in the middle of the day to say, well, I'm thinking of you, etc. All the attentions too, like, I thought of you, I know you like this, so I bought it for you to eat, etc. And then also, when we are together, it will necessarily be all the proximity, whether physical or emotional, expressing our love through gestures, through intimacy, through hugs, things like that, actually. I think that's a very strong way to show it. And in the same way, I think he shows it a lot by simply being present to reassure me again, to support me, to dream with me about many things.

I: Yes, so physical attentions, but also paying attention to the person in a mental way, so to speak.

P: Yes, exactly. I think we say it as much through communication, writing, speaking, as through gestures, actions, or attentions, actually.

I: I'd like you to tell me about one of the last positive interactions you had with (partner).

P: So, we're not together right now, so it's through messages. But I find all our conversations are positive, in general. So, I don't know if you want something very, very positive or just...

I: The last one that comes to mind, that you consider a positive interaction.

P: Yes, very sincerely, we often have positive interactions. As I told you, he's someone who takes a lot of time to listen to me. Right now, I'm in a huge questioning phase about my career path. It really occupies a huge part of my brain. I think, I sleep, I dream about it constantly. I'm very, very connected to what I can do with my life afterwards. And he's listening to that. So, the last one was just yesterday, I was talking to him a bit about how I felt and what paths I was considering. He's there to listen and advise me and to tell me, you'll make it, actually. So, it's another example of how supportive he is.

I: So, you said it was a positive interaction, it was the fact that he was listening.

P: Listening and supportive, yes, exactly. Then, there are other very positive interactions where we laugh, actually. We have fun over little things. We do stuff like everyone else, sending each other funny videos or things like that. And it's very nice to be able to bring some lightness into all this. Where I think we have a very cerebral relationship, since we are both quite cerebral for once. So, we think a lot and we tend to have these essential or fundamental, existential discussions sometimes. And we bring a lot of lightness through little everyday things that make us laugh or things we share that make us dream, cute animals, things like that.

I: And on the contrary, I'd like you to tell me about one of the last negative interactions you had with (partner).

P: It dates back quite a while, at least for me. One comes to mind, and it's really very distant. It was [1-5] and a half years ago, well not [1-5] and a half years, but [1-5] year and a half ago, sorry. And it's almost one of the only times when we were a bit... We had a bit of a clash, let's say, and we were... Well, we weren't agreeing on... Well, we were hiking and we had to take a path, etc. And he already knew this hike and had the map, and he knew where he was going, how he was going, and I didn't know and never saw the map. So, after a while, it annoyed me because I felt completely out of control. And so, I wanted to see this map and in the end, he was holding on to it. So, yes, at some point, we argued a bit about that. I don't even remember how it happened and why and how, but it's true that... I said something that was probably a bit sharp and not very benevolent at all. And he was a bit surprised and said, well, great, thanks for saying that. And I think it's... Well, he walked off, and I had to run after him to try to say, well, better we talk about it than be in contradiction like that. It's really one of the moments I remember most. But otherwise, recently, I can't really say anything.

I: If that's the last one you remember, yes. And why do you think it was a negative interaction?

P: Because we were in disagreement, I got angry, I was no longer benevolent towards him, and I probably chose to say something that would hurt him to get a reaction, and he rightly got defensive and thought no. Well, I think at that moment, he hadn't noticed that I had little say in the situation from the beginning. So, I think it stemmed from a misunderstanding and a lack of communication at the time. Where I think I need to learn to express how I feel more often and communicate rather than letting things build up. And I often let the pressure cooker build up until it explodes. And it's better if I try to be more authentic gradually, actually. So, that's it.

I: Yeah, so the lack of communication.

P: Yes, clearly, I think that was it, and then the misunderstanding, yeah, which comes from the lack of communication, so yes.

I: I see. I'd like you to tell me now, according to you, about the challenges in your relationship.

P: Well, the first challenge for me will really be to be able to live together full time. And that's going to be a challenge, as I was saying, in terms of my space, meaning mental space, physical space, etc. I know I need a lot of space, and again, I'm not very fusionnal, so sometimes I need to recenter myself a lot. I'm also in a period of my life, as I mentioned, where I'm very taken up by my own issues and where I don't feel at all, or very little, really available to listen to (partner). At the moment, I don't feel available and I don't like being like that at all. It's true that it's something I need to work on more with myself. Those will really be the two challenges, I think, for us. It will be ensuring that we can find enough space for each other to be independent, to do the things we need to do to realign ourselves, to be, in quotes, well. And then also, regarding intimacy, I feel that if we don't have enough space for ourselves and moments for us, etc., it

becomes more difficult because there's this feeling of... How to say? Feeling a bit stifled, and I think that's something... It's going to be a challenge for us to make sure we don't stifle each other. At least more for me, probably, because he has had longer relationships than I have. This is my first long relationship where I might live with him. I've never lived with my boyfriends before. So, it's something that scares me a little.

I: Yes, finding the balance between personal space and shared space.

P: Yes, that's it.

I: And are there challenges you've already faced in the past?

P: The distance, I think for some, would be a challenge. For me, it wasn't that much because I also have a lot of long-distance friends. So, unfortunately, I'm quite used to it. But yes, it was surely a challenge that we managed to overcome. I think... There are other challenges we're currently overcoming, rather than those we've already put behind us. Whether it's long-term distance, where we don't see each other for longer periods than usual, and also getting through this phase of uncertainty because we're quite uncertain, I think, about our future, both of us. I'm talking about the distant future, like in two years, for example. We know what the near future is. But I think it will be important for us to get through these stages.

I: Yes, yes, the distance, yes.

P: Yes, and also not knowing... Well, I think it's easier when you have a path that's, in quotes, mapped out. And here, neither of us really knows where we'll be in [1-5] years.

I: Not having...

P: Not having a long-term vision, actually. So, we'll have to make sure our paths align. And that will inevitably mean compromises because we'll have to make choices about work or other things related to each other. And I think that's very difficult because when you're open and have a lot of possibilities, it's always easier to let professional opportunities come to us, but when you're constrained by a person, by a place, etc., it's another thing.

I: Yes, making decisions considering there's another person involved.

P: Yes, that's it, which, for me, hasn't been the case until now. I've always made the decisions that were right for me at that moment, whether it was moving elsewhere, choosing another job, having a job that, I don't know, requires a lot of work, not having normal hours. Those were things I didn't even think about because I had no attachments. And now, it will be about making decisions together. And that's going to be a challenge for me, clearly.

I: Yes, yes, I understand. So, we know that in relationships, not everything is rosy, and conflicts do happen. I'd like you to talk to me about the conflicts, perhaps, and disputes in your relationship. Maybe their frequency, the most common causes, and how you resolve them.

P: As I said, I feel like we have very few conflicts. Again, thanks to him more than me, because I can be quite... I can be quite quick-tempered. But since he's very calm, it calms things down. So, the few conflicts we've had, he has really quickly defused them, actually. It's just that I pull the pin and then, click, I pull it out. I'm ready to throw it. And he takes it, puts the pin back in, and that's it. If I were to give a metaphor, it's a bit like that. He quickly calms things down, really quickly. He just decides it's not worth it. So, that's it, he calms things down. Hop, the little soufflé deflates. And then, there won't be any anger. Whereas I could get all worked up. So, we've had very few conflicts. And yes, I agree that a relationship isn't all rosy. But very sincerely, since I've been with (partner), it's simple. We've probably had other conflicts than the one I told you about earlier with the hike. But I can't remember them because they are, in quotes, so insignificant

and didn't affect me emotionally that much. Whereas in my previous relationships, I could enumerate millions of conflicts, really. So, here, no, I couldn't find another example other than the one I told you earlier.

I: How frequent would you say they are, then? You say there are few.

P: Well, honestly, I would say twice a year, real conflicts. I mean, yes, little conflicts where, I don't know, we don't quite agree on a subject, but I find that normal. I think conflict is healthy sometimes too. So, I mean real conflicts where it doesn't seem healthy at all because the approach was wrong. So, yes, no, I would say really very few. Like, twice a year, let's say.

I: And minor disputes, just disagreements, are they more frequent, then?

P: Not even that often. I don't know, maybe once every [1-5] months, we'll... We'll say, well, I don't know, maybe... No, not even. Generally, we're quite understanding, I don't know. We give each other a lot of slack. We're really not the type to, I don't know, note that you forgot to buy milk or you forgot... Things like that, we don't care, I think. At least, I do, and he does too, it seems. Of course, we'll note that the other person, for example, is always doing this or that. But it's more... We laugh about it because, I don't know, for example... If I give an example, it won't come to mind, but... Yes, well, for example, I don't clean very often. It's really not my favorite thing. So, I'm not the best at cleaning or tidying. And he's rather neat. So, every time I come to his place, it becomes a bit of a... How to say? I put all my things everywhere. That's it. And he always points it out. But for all that... Well, he doesn't always point it out. No, not even, but he does point it out. But it makes him laugh, actually. So, it's not something where I feel he's making a comment for me to change. So, I don't change. And that's it.

I: And earlier, you said it was (partner) who often defused conflicts. How does he do it exactly?

P: Generally, he stays really calm. And he doesn't enter into the conflict. If I'm taking a stance, he'll just say it's not a big deal. Or if... I don't know. He argues, but not to make me change my mind. He gives his point of view so that I can understand it. But not so that I have to follow it. And since he stays calm and doesn't enter into the conflict, little by little, I calm down. And otherwise, I can tell from his posture that he's uncomfortable or something. And that calms me down too, little by little. And I think that gradually, it's him who... He can also use humor, but maybe not that much in conflicts. But at least, he can sometimes turn a topic I'm taking too seriously into a joke. And otherwise, through gestures. It's... Well, then, I don't know, a hug or holding me or things like that. And that's how it defuses.

I: So, he takes a step back and makes a little gesture.

P: Yes.

I: And I'd like you to tell me about the ways you maintain your relationship, aside from these little gestures.

P: Well, yes, that's a good question. I think we try, at least regularly, to break away from the routine. To say, well, it's easy to come home and sit on the couch and watch a series because it's nice, it's relaxing, and some nights we just want to do that. But we also try to say, well, no, some nights we'll go to a restaurant, have a drink, take time where we're really together and talk, try to listen to each other. I think that's something we try to cultivate a bit, at least. And otherwise, it's, as I said, having common goals and trying to achieve them together and motivating each other with that. So, sharing visions of the future together, I think that's what helps us maintain a good symbiosis. Otherwise, I think it's keeping communication even when we're apart. Just sending little things. As I said, we also have our little cute things we share all

the time, which are a bit of our way of staying connected. And that's it. After that, I think we're like many couples, things go very well between us. But obviously, we're caught up in the stress of life, the lack of time, work, all the things we think about that make us not in the perfect romantic movie all the time. We have a lot of things that have become routine, and we share a daily routine together. But it's not always romantic candlelit evenings. We share very simple things, a daily life. So, it's about sharing and breaking the routine. We try to break the routine a bit, but we're very much embedded in a routine for now. But to be honest, right now, I don't have the mental space or presence to do otherwise. Maybe in some time, if we're both in clearer positions for ourselves, with less stress, maybe we can take more couple time, etc. We did a lot of that at the beginning, but now we're more in a phase where we try to let things flow, and for me, maybe, my priorities are elsewhere than maintaining the passion of the couple, let's say. But that doesn't mean I forget it completely or take it for granted. But it's true that right now, we have a lot of other important things on our minds. So, we're not constantly trying to break the routine. Sometimes, we just want to do the routine, curl up on the couch, and that's great.

I: So, it's not necessarily the main element.

P: No, not right now, at least not. Even though I know it's something to pay attention to. I don't want to spend [6-10] years like this without giving some priority to the other because it's important to do that, and I'm aware of it. But I really think there are moments in life where it's just too complicated to put too much pressure everywhere. So, I've taken some pressure off my relationship, which is one of the things that makes it work well with (partner) for me. He seems to accept that there's a moment when the pressure dropped and that I'm not too much in the mode of always having to measure up. It's not that either, it's just accepting being how we are in moments where maybe we don't feel great and don't have all the energy for our partner. It's just very simple everyday moments we share and not an incredible romance.

I: Yes, I see. So, on the contrary, I'd like to know what might make you leave (partner)?

P: Well, clearly, if there were a change in the sense that there would be no more respect, less benevolence, or if I felt he was detaching, or if I felt there were very different directions we wanted to take, different values. For example, if one of us wants a child and the other doesn't, it's obvious that at some point, we have to make the right decision, I think. I think that's the main thing. Besides, unless our lives send us in two totally opposite directions, and even then, I think it's possible to make it work long-distance or something. But sometimes it can be really difficult. I imagine if I want to completely change my life tomorrow and go raise goats in the mountains and he doesn't, well, that can be complicated. So yes, life changes actually. If there are major life changes, I think, unfortunately, we would have to part ways. But we can also see how to make it work. I admit that something I couldn't stand, because it's my opinion and my way of seeing the couple, but infidelity or something of that nature, for me, it wouldn't be possible. I don't have an open mind about that. Probably because I see the couple as something to be lived between two people and not more. I fully respect those who want to do it, but I don't think that's how I want to live it. So yes, for me, it would be very difficult. That or a huge lie, something like lying about a huge part of their life or things like that, for me, honesty and trust are essential. Hum... That's it.

I: So infidelity falls under lack of trust, and otherwise different life perspectives.

P: That's it.

I: And would you say this relationship is good for you?

P: Yes, very good. Really extremely positive.

I: Yeah, in what way? Do you feel maybe it helps you in your functioning?

P: Completely, it helps me. I think it calms and relaxes me too. And it also allows me to spread my wings in other dimensions of my life, in quotes. And I think it's also fulfilling, actually. It's really...

I: Yes, yes. Sorry, I didn't hear the end because it cut out.

P: Ah, yes. I was just saying it's fulfilling.

I: Okay, yes. Do you have an example of a situation where you feel it helped you?

P: Clearly, my parents' divorce, for example, I think it would have been much harder to go through if I hadn't been in a relationship with him at that time. And if I had still been in my toxic relationship. I think if that had been the case, it would have been very difficult. Then, to give something very concrete, I met (partner) when I had just come out of my depressive state, actually. A depressive state that lasted almost [6-10] months. And so I gradually came out of it also thanks to my relationship with him, completely. So yes, it was very positive for all that. And now, I think he supports me a lot in my work, simply.

I: Yes, it's support and it helps you to flourish.

P: Yes. And to gain confidence in myself and to take more of my place in certain situations where otherwise you can quickly get crushed without even thinking you deserve better or have the right to want better. I think that's also something (partner) made me realize, that it's not normal not to be treated well. Where before, honestly, sometimes you don't even realize you're being mistreated.

I: And you mentioned it might have helped develop your self-confidence. Do you feel this relationship has changed you, that you have evolved since before?

P: Clearly, I've evolved but strangely, I wouldn't say changed because on the contrary, he has allowed me to find myself again, to be who I am 100%, to reconnect with things I had somewhat lost with the other relationship. So I think he helps me to spread out, to evolve in terms of who I am rather than changing me. Where other relationships make you change but not in a positive way. So rather evolving.

I: Yes, so you have evolved in the sense that it expands your personality.

P: Yes. Yes, and also, well, some things have changed in the sense that I try to share things with him about his passions too. So, there's a whole part of my life that's taking a certain direction because it's also what he, well, what we both but maybe him more, try to develop.

I: So maybe also in your life perspectives, it makes you evolve.

P: Yes.

I: And on his side, (partner), do you feel he has evolved too from before to now?

P: I don't know if he has evolved, it would be better for him to tell me, but I've noticed some small changes between him at the beginning and him now with me. And with people in general maybe. If there are things I notice, for example, I have a very important sensitivity to animals. I love animals very much. It's something that... I grew up with animals, he didn't. And so at the beginning, he didn't really have an understanding of animals as such, and now he is really starting to acquire that sensitivity too, to see them differently, to understand them a bit better. Some things have changed about that. I think there are other little things here and there where we nourish each other. So actually, yes, he has probably more awareness of certain things and

vice versa. We come from quite different backgrounds. So it necessarily helps us understand a different environment than the one we grew up in, let's say.

I: You share your interests, your points of view.

P: Yes, that's it, exactly. Because I have no trouble sharing things with him that he's not very fond of. Animals, for example, were really something he didn't understand at the beginning, my attraction to animals, and now he does. On the other hand, I also love spirituality, and he doesn't at all, and it's not something he has integrated. He listens to me talk about it, but he hasn't integrated it. It's also because he liked animals from the start, I think, that he changed. Because he doesn't take every direction I take and vice versa. But there are still things where we come together. We start sharing more, where before maybe we didn't have that interest. For example, he loves running, and I've started running more with him, so that's something that changes because we understand each other's point of view or share passions.

I: So, yes, the evolution has happened in shared interests...

P: Shared or not.

I: Yes. Now I'd like to know if you feel safe in this relationship.

P: Yes, very. As I said, extremely safe, very reassuring, and really without a doubt.

I: Yes, you feel you can open up and there will be no judgment, and he will be there for you.

P: Yes.

I: Great. So to finish, I'd like to quickly address another dimension of relationships, sexuality. We know it's a dimension that can be more or less important depending on the person. So I'd like to know what it means for you. What is the place of sexuality in your relationship?

P: That's a really complicated question, especially for me. Sexuality is something that's not easy to talk about for me at all. I think I give it much less importance than he does, and I think that's maybe one of the more complicated points to manage somehow because we don't have the same needs or desires at all, and it's something that might cause a lot of guilt for me. Because I'm really aware that there's a gap, that we're not on the same level. And so I think he has helped me gain more confidence in that area, to be more in tune with myself, to know how to express more what I feel, what I want, and when I want it. So again, on this point, he is extremely respectful, really there's nothing to complain about. He's extremely attentive, patient, not insistent at all. He's really someone who listens to the other and doesn't put pressure. But I still manage to put pressure on myself because I know and I feel that there's a gap. We may not have the same needs. And so I know it's very important, that it's a way to cultivate intimacy, etc. I'm really aware of that, but it's maybe a part of me that I haven't taken the time to really develop or at least explore. I'm still trying to understand that part.

I: And would you say you are satisfied with your sex life?

P: Yes, of course, but I have so much guilt that sometimes I put pressure on myself about it. Where I feel pretty happy, but I have this impression that he might not be, and that puts pressure on me. So, that's it.

I: So, to finish, I'll show you a scale. I'll present it to you if I can... every time. Here, tell me if you can see it.

P: So, here it is.

I: Ah, great. Oops, I'll get there.

P: Yeah, I see it well.

I: Is it displayed?

P: Yes.

I: So, as you can see, it's between 1 and 9, from not at all to completely true. If I ask you, in general, my partner really listens to me.

P: I would say 9.

I: 9?

P: Yes.

I: Why would you say 9?

P: Because as I said, he's someone who really listens, who is really present and responds to what I say. It's not just listening where I talk, talk, talk, and he didn't listen. He's really present.

I: Yes, yeah. So, if I ask you, my partner is generally attentive to my needs.

P: I would say 8.

I: 8?

P: I would say 8, not 9 because I think we're quite different in that he's maybe a little more fusionnal than I am. He may need a little more closeness than I do, so generally, I think he's really attentive to all my needs. Maybe just the need to have more time for myself is what lacks.

I: Do you have a concrete example of a moment?

P: It's not really moments, but it's just that, for example, when I have friends visiting or something, he might want to come with us, or I feel he wants to come with us when I might just want to be with my friends.

I: Yes, I see.

P: But that's it. He doesn't even tell me, but I know, I feel it, and so I tend to put pressure on myself thinking he might want to, and so, that's it.

I: Now, if I ask you, in general, how satisfied are you with your relationship?

P: I would say completely satisfied.

I: So that's 10, yes?

P: Yeah.

I: And so, your degree of satisfaction with your relationship between 0 and 10, what would it be?

P: Always 10, then.

I: And why 10, why not 9?

P: Because I think again, there are moments in life in relationships, so I'm very satisfied with our relationship right now. Even if, as I said earlier, there are little things where we may not be completely in sync. But I think it's also things that need to be worked on individually. For example, for me, sexuality is something that I see as my responsibility to work on myself, to pass certain milestones, to be more in tune with certain things, etc. So, I don't really feel it's about the relationship, it's more about self-development. It's also about doing the necessary work oneself, and as I said, I feel very taken up by other things. And this relationship helps me in that direction. It's not all rosy, it's not perfect, there may be challenges, but I'm satisfied right now with what it brings me.

I: Great, so I'll stop the presentation and also stop the recording. Thank you.